

While in Rome, Leonardo completed his last major painting, *St. John the Baptist*. In this striking picture, John appears to emerge from the shadows. Critics commented that he looked considerably better fed than in many other paintings. St. John was usually shown as a thin figure who, having lived in the desert, had not had the chance to eat many good meals.

Painting *St. John the Baptist* may have been a struggle for the aging Leonardo, since he now had ailments that made some of his movements difficult. But Leonardo still had enough determination and strength to accept King Francis I's invitation and manage one final move—to France.